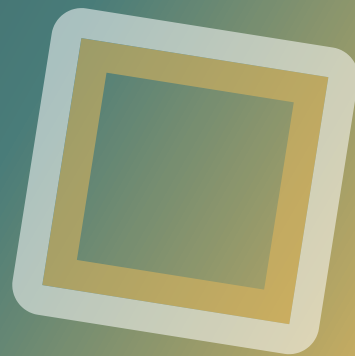


The Borrow Box

A good lunchtime idea still has to answer fair questions.



The empty crate beside the oval

At the first Student Voice meeting of term, Imani placed an empty blue crate in the middle of the table. "This is the Borrow Box," she said. "Not yet, anyway." Her plan was simple: at the beginning of lunch, students could borrow skipping ropes, chalk, soft balls, card games and drawing boards. At the end, they would return each item to the labelled crate.

Imani had noticed that the basketball court filled quickly while other students waited near the fence or sat on the steps. Some wanted an active game but did not have equipment. Others wanted a quieter choice. She believed a small shared collection could make lunch feel more welcoming without telling anyone what kind of play they had to choose.

Riverbank Primary should run a four-week Borrow Box trial at lunch and review what it teaches us.

Her first poster ended with: "Anyone against the Borrow Box wants students to be bored." Mr Patel asked her to pause. The sentence made disagreement sound selfish. It did not tell readers what a careful person might genuinely worry about.

The questions behind the yes

Jayden liked the idea but pointed to the blue crate. "What happens when a ball disappears, or when one group keeps the same things all lunch?" he asked. Elif added, "Will the box only have loud games? Sometimes I want something to do with one friend."

These were counterarguments: fair concerns an audience could hold even when they liked the purpose of the idea.

Mark the feature

- C** claim or action
- ?** genuine concern
- R** response or safeguard
- X** unfair dismissal

Find two fair concerns. Then find the sentence that makes disagreement sound selfish.

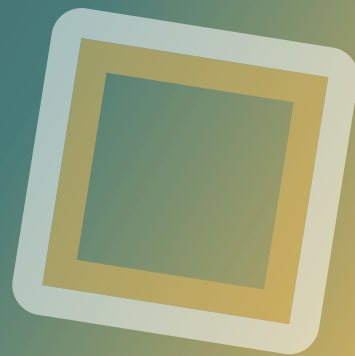
Ask yourself

Would the other person recognise this as their real concern?

Does the response answer the exact concern?

Answer the concern

A rebuttal does more than repeat an opinion.



A response that fits the worry

Imani rewrote the poster. She began by admitting that shared equipment could be lost and that a busy collection line could waste lunch time. She explained why this mattered: a system that causes frustration or uses money carelessly would not be fair to students or staff.

Some people may worry that equipment will be lost or that a queue will take too long. Those are sensible concerns because a shared system must be fair and easy to use. However, a labelled tub, a quick sign-out card and a five-minute collection window would let us test a routine instead of guessing. The Borrow Box should begin as a four-week trial, with an end-of-lunch count and a record of waiting time.

The revised response does not promise that every item will return or that every student will enjoy the same activity. It offers a small action that can be checked. The group also planned to include chalk and drawing boards alongside active equipment, and to ask students which choices were missing.

Only one reply works

Repeats the claim

"Fun is more important than waiting."

Attacks people

"People who complain about queues never support good ideas."

Answers the concern

"A five-minute collection window and class roster could limit waiting time; the trial can record whether that works."

The ACK bridge

A

Acknowledge the real worry.

C

Connect a reason or safeguard.

K

Keep the claim with action.

Writer's test

Put a line from the concern to your answer. Does it match?

Write to the fictional principal. You may support, change or reject the trial. You must represent one fair concern and answer it with a workable response.